



FOOTBALL FANDOM

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Football fans showy their identity though the use of symbolism
and fashion?

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CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION	4
IDENTITY	5
SYMBOLISM	13
FASHION IN FOOTBALL	19
CONCLUSION	24
LIST OF ILLUSTRATION	26
LIST OF REFENCES	27
BIBLIOGRAPHY	29
APENDIX	30

INTRODUCTION

“Football is the beautiful game. It has the power to inspire, to unite people in a way that little else does.” (Pelé). Football is played on all 7 continents by men, women and children. The game is easy in its simplest form. Kick a circular ball into the net, the simplicity of the game makes it so world-wide with pretty much anyone able to access the limited equipment. Football can be played in all conditions and doesn't really have an age restriction. The true origins of football are unknown, the basis for the modern game is less complicated and can be traced to a medieval village ball game in 19th century England. It gradually moulded and developed into the elite boys' public schools of Victorian England such as Winchester School. (BBC sport). Football has been a sport for a long time but it's not players, but fans that are a massive part of the modern game. They provide the platform for the sport to grow and become what it is today.



Fig 1: French fans celebrating after winning the world cup (Fletcher, 2024)

“The term ‘fan’, as a contraction of ‘fantastic’, was first used to describe keen baseball supporters in the sports columns of US newspapers in the 1890s” (p10, Savage enthusiasm, Brown, 2017). The game has become much larger in recent time, due to the following the game has acquired, Jock (John) Stein was a player and manager from Scotland, he once said “Football is nothing without fans”. The game is elevated by fans in many ways, this may be through the money brought into the game, the atmosphere of games or the support given to teams. Fans are

such a crucial part of our game and today I would like to investigate how fans are able to show their support to the clubs they have grown to love?

This dissertation examines the relationship between football clubs and their fans, with a particular focus on how a fan's can express their loyalty and that they identify with the club. To gather insights, I conducted a questionnaire-based study involving 10 participants, who were numbered 1-10 to maintain their anonymity. The questionnaire targeted football fans aged 18-24, a demographic that is in touch with both the fashion and sporting worlds. The study explores how football culture informs fans' personal styles, providing a deeper understanding of the symbolic and cultural significance of football in the context of fashion. This work complements my Final Major Project (FMP), which investigates the ties between fashion and sport, specifically examining how the football world shapes and expresses identity through fashion.

This research project should answer how football fans show their identity through the use of symbolism and fashion? In my first chapter I will investigate identity, how a club's identity is made and how fans can perceive this. Also, how fans can express their identity through clothing.

IDENTITY



Fig 2: (own image)

“Identity refers to our sense of who we are as individuals and as members of social groups. It also refers to our sense of how others may perceive and label us” (Facing History & Ourselves, 2021). Every football club has its own crest and colours unique to them, serving as a distinct identifier. This was to avoid confusion on the pitch but has evolved into something fans actively buy into when they choose to support a team. By wearing the club's colours and merchandise, fans adopt the club's identity as their own. This creates a connection through a shared uniform and language. Participant 8, from the questionnaire I conducted, reflected

this idea, stating that wearing a football top is a form of identity. They described it as “creates an identity” emphasising that it is a way to show their support and loyalty. The club’s identity can be made many ways whether it’s the success of the team, the history or geographical location of the club. Wolverhampton Wanderers (better known as Wolves) were founded in 1877 as St. Lukes FC. The name was changed to Wolverhampton Wanderers, inspired by its wandering nature in the early games, mixed with the local legend Wulfrun, a noblewoman in the area. Joe prince-wright Lead Writer and Editor of NBC Sports with a focus on the EPL (English primer league) has the view that the name and wolflike crest gives the team a distinct identity across the world. (Prince-Wright, 2023). This quote highlights how a football club’s identity is shaped by both its historical origins and cultural symbols.

“The identity of a football team is effortlessly illustrated on its crest, thus succinctly expressing an abundance of historical and cultural evidence.” (Christos Kassimeris, 2024). A football clubs badge represents its identity, it’s how a club is recognised along with the colour of the club. Fans seek a connection to their clubs, and the simplest way to show this is by wearing the club’s crest. Doing this shows support for their team and openly shows a person’s characteristics and views. Here Clair Butler examines the relationship between clothes and how they can be more than just fashion. Butler says, “your clothes are so much more than just being pieces of fabric you drape over your body.” (Butler, 2024). She is saying that clothing has evolved from something to protect you from the elements to something that has meaning to you and are able to express yourself in. In this case football fans want to express their love for their club, and they do this through dressing in the team’s kit and colours.

Fans show their support in various ways, from buying the latest kit each season to wearing an old shirt to showcase their long-standing loyalty. Some fans go all out, dressing entirely in their team’s colours. In Germany one obvious example is BVB (Borussia Dortmund), at home games they create large-scale fan displays (choreos). The displays are organised by fan groups/ultras such as The ‘Unity’ and ‘Desperados Dortmund’, these groups spend weeks designing the display for the game and organize fundraising events to cover the costs of materials. BVB support these displays and often help with organisation, before the game parts of the displays (tifos) will be left in the correct seats for the fans to interact with, creating this awesome effect. These visual displays are ways fans show their support and help their team, showing this level of dedication and support gives

the players an increased level of motivation whilst also raising the level of atmosphere within the ground. This idea is similarly mirrored in fashion shows, where the clothes displayed on the runway by a particular brand reflect elements of the brand's identity, aligned with the current season and trends. Fans of the brand often imitate what's being showcased on the runway. By doing so, they associate themselves with the brand, perhaps in a more subtle way compared to fans wearing football merchandise, but the process is the same.



Fig 3: Yellow Wall, BVB fans at the Signal Iduna Park Stadium (Devang Desai, 2015)

James Bowskill a sports photographer that grew up in Manchester watch football from a young age, he suggests football goes beyond sport and is a big part of societies culture. He came to this conclusion from being a fan his whole life and even more through becoming a sports photographer. "Football withholds a significance in so many people's lives which is unrivalled by anything. Being a football fan is such a concentration of emotion, revealing aspects of love, loyalty, and passion, but also at other times, misery and loneliness" (Bowskill, 2023).

This suggests for some football is a way and results can control one's emotions. According to Dixon P13, a justification of moderate patriotism in sport, a team's success reflects well on the team, and fans, in turn have accomplished something through their team. Fans show their support in hopes to boost the team's chances of success, therefore improving their mood. To achieve this, fans can do very little but show encouragement to try give that slight edge over their opponent. Fans do this by wearing their support, showing people/the players that they are here for them. Wearing their team's kit /colour is the simplest way of providing support. It's a form of subculture that could be compared to the likes of the Punks. Punks rebelled against the norms of mainstream fashion with their distinctive looks. (Lower Block, 2024c). Punk fashion is a form of expression to show they are a part of this subculture; this can be seen within football when fans dress to support their team.

'Enclothed Cognition' is the psychological phenomenon where the clothes you wear directly influence your cognitive processes. (Butler, 2024). Butler is an Award-winning Personal Stylist that believes the clothes you wear can affect your mood. In this case fans will wear their clubs' kits or colours to excite them for the game they are about to watch. This mindset is ignited by wearing your matchday outfit, the clothing is like battle armour for fans and they are ready to battle with their team. Fans clothing not only influences their mindset but also strengthens their connection to the team, almost turning themselves into the 12th man.



Fig 4: The Twelfth Man. Mexico fans ahead of their match against Norway in the USA 1994 world cup. (Davis , 2023)

A football club's identity naturally evolves over time, but certain factors can significantly influence how it is perceived. Niamh Foley a Marketing Coordinator states that "Brand partnerships are key aspects of the business side of football, providing crucial financial support and resources." (Foley, 2024). She is saying that sponsorships are an important aspect for clubs' economic wellbeing. However, these deals can also reshape a club's identity, as the reputation and values of associated brands can impact the public perception. In the 1990-91 season, Scarborough, a small football club from North Yorkshire, England, secured a sponsorship deal with Black Death Vodka. The decision to feature this controversial brand on their shirts sparked outrage within the football community, as many felt the brand's name was darkly humorous and inappropriate for a sports team. With a name that evokes a grim image, Black Death Vodka was not the most welcoming or family-friendly sponsor, especially for a small club hoping to grow its fan base and attract young supporters. The U.S.-based brand was later banned from sale, underscoring the controversial nature of the partnership. For Scarborough, having "Black Death Vodka" on their kits highlights the importance of choosing a sponsorship that reflects the clubs' values and align with the fans, as they are the voice of the club. This can be associated with brands producing graphic T-shirts featuring derogatory imagery. While these designs may appeal to some, they often lead others to associate both the brand and the wearer with the negative connotations of the imagery.



Fig 5: Scarborough 1990 Home kit. (classicshirts, 2024)

Sponsorship from cigarette, alcohol, and gambling companies has had a prominent history of the top league of English football. In the early days of English football, cigarette sponsorship was common, especially before the founding of the Premier League in 1992. Many leagues and tournaments in the 1980s were sponsored by tobacco brands like Marlboro and Rothmans. Alcohol sponsorship has a long legacy in the Premier League. In the 1990s and 2000s, several major clubs had partnerships with alcohol brands, e.g. Liverpool with Carlsberg from 1992-2010, and Everton with Chang beer for many years. Over time, clubs have reduced partnerships with alcohol and tobacco brands in response to social responsibility concerns and more modern club values. However, gambling companies are one of the most visible revenue streams for Premier League clubs in the past two decades. The Financial Times estimates this sponsorship is valued at around £60 million (fcbusiness, 2024). Ben Fisher covers football in the Midlands, south-west England and Wales for the Guardian, he says that Bournemouth was the 11th team in the premier league to take a gambling company as a sponsorship in 2023/25 season. (Fisher, 2024). This makes over half the EPL teams sponsored by gambling companies with many of them having them as their main shirts sponsor. When asked does the sponsorship of your club matter to you? and why? Participant 9 answered “Betting sponsors are tacky and don’t represent fanbases”. This is a fan that is not happy with gambling sponsorships and thinks they don’t reflect the fan base well. Fans are surrounded by these promotions and therefore likely to use them.



Fig 6: Newcastle United and West Ham United 2022 kits (Kleinman, 2022)



Fig 7: Fernando Torres wearing the 2008-2010 home kit. (ELLIS, 2024)

“When advertising promotes unhealthy behaviours, it can have very real, very negative effects” (Charly Jaffe, 2015). Charly, an emotional health expert, argues that advertising can have a significant negative impact when it promotes unhealthy behaviours, affecting the audience in harmful ways. This can be interpreted within football terms as the sponsorships chosen by the clubs have a big impact on the fans.

Amy Curran the CEO of Claret, an alcohol logistics company, claims that “years of enjoyment at games has led to an association of joy with alcohol, and tobacco.” (Curran, 2024). This is suggesting that years of easy access to the promotion of alcohol and tobacco have normalised their association of drinking and smoking at games, turning it into a characteristic of fans. During my primary research, when asked about the characteristics of a football fan, alcohol related responses were among the most popular, alongside other antisocial behaviour. (see appendix). These are stereotypical traits of a football fan, as over the years, fans have taken in these marketing messages and developed the habits of an ‘unsociable’ member of the public. This characteristic of fans has been brought upon them by these sponsorship and brand deals, altering one’s identity, whilst they try to fit in with the football fan norm. Similarly, fashion plays a role in this identity transformation, subtly encouraged to adopt certain clothing styles, people internalise these fashion trends as symbols of coolness or mainstream and want to fit in with these groups.



Fig 8: English football fans. (Rubin, 2024)

Football fans want to show their support and often do this by aligning themselves with the club’s identity and showing this by representing the club’s merchandise. However, this is not chosen by them and certain aspects can change the identity can therefore impact fans. The second chapter will focus on symbolism in football. I shall talk about the types of symbolism embedded in football and how important these are for fan communities. I will also investigate how clubs’ uses of symbolism can positively affect the fans.

SYMBOLISM



Fig 9: Aresnal FC bagde appearsin the streets of india. (Clift, 2024)

There are many symbolic features within football, whether it be as simple as the badge of the club or the chants sung by fans. I would like to investigate the importance of the badge. A participant in my questionnaire thought that symbolism represents shared values, identity, and pride, helping fans feel connected to their club and each other. (participant 7). They are stating the importance of symbolism within football and that they help create a community. A club's badge often has historical meaning behind it, this may be inspired by the geographic location or the founding history. AS Roma, the Italian football club, has a badge with deep historical meaning that ties the club to the city of Rome's rich heritage. Gareth Thomas a historian with a love for football, writing for his football history boys page, says that the club's badge prominently features the Capitoline Wolf (or Lupa Capitolina), which depicts a she-wolf nursing two infant twins, Romulus and Remus. According to Roman mythology, these twins were abandoned and raised by a she-wolf in a cave near the Palatine Hill. Romulus eventually went on to find the city of Rome. (Thomas, 2013). This myth is a significant part of Rome's ancient history, symbolising strength, resilience, and loyalty to one's origins. The she-wolf and twins are key symbols of Rome itself, and by incorporating them into AS Roma's badge serves as a reminder of the club's

connection to the city and its past storied. The badge not only honours the city's legacy but also establishes a sense of pride and identity for the fans, who view themselves as protectors of Rome's heritage through their support of the club. The deep-rooted symbolism of the Capitoline Wolf gives AS Roma's badge a meaning that resonates with its supporters and makes it an emblem of cultural pride and historical continuity.



Fig 10: AS Roma badge development over the years. (r/ASRoma, 2023)

“Unsurprisingly, the nature of the club’s crest - and the preservation of the defining features and values depicted within it - is an emotive issue for fan bases. The elements of football badges typically resonate directly with supporters; local influences, familiar imagery, and powerful slogans all play their part. Therefore, any adjustments to this vital piece of a club’s persona can cause a major stir among supporters” (Murray, 2024). Ryan Murray with a lifelong association with football, now a sports journalist has a keen interest in the fan’s connection with symbolism in their clubs explains that a club’s badge holds deep meaning for fans, serving as a powerful symbol of their connection to the club. Badges represent the fans views and in many cases their pride, therefore the crest being changed can often disrupt the sense of identity within the community. 77.8% participants of my primary research said that changing a club’s symbolisms has a negative effect for them. This is proving that symbolism has meaning to fans, and disrupting them feels like an attack. In 2020 Inter Milan changed their badged sparking uneasiness within fans who felt that the new design lost the historical character of the original. A lot of this uneasiness was displayed on Twitter and other platforms “I think it’s pathetic that clubs are willing to discard their history and identity for what is a branding fad. Minimalism today, something else tomorrow.” (ISqueezeBlackheads, 2021). The design was a minimalistic design losing some details that had been a key factor in the club for many decades. The club decided to drop the FC in the badge (standing for football club) to move on with the more modern design of today. Many fans felt that it was abandoning the club’s tradition and identity and was made to look more corporate. This reaction shows the deep connection fans have with the symbols of their club seeing them as tradition and loyalty.



Fig 11: social media outrage of Inter Milans badge change. (Mayo, 2021)

“Football fans don’t really like change” (Rushden, 2024). Therefore, playing around with symbolism can be dangerous with some change not being welcome. The England 2024 Euros kit was a big talking point in the lead up to the tournament in Germany. The kit (by Nike, a non-English brand) changed the colour of the Saint George’s cross from the classic red and white to a mixture of colours. Nike claimed it was a playful update to the cross of St George which appears on the collar to unite and inspire. The change annoyed many including the Prime Minister at the time Rishi Sunak, who said he “prefers the original and the national flag is a source of pride and identity that shouldn’t be meddled with.” (Armstrong, 2024). Rishi was backed up by many when he highlights how altering symbolic elements can provoke negative responses as they have deeply ingrained traditions and identity ties. Stuart Holliday a Sport Psychologist researching into how and why football fans are so loyal claims that research has shown that fans believe they are the team, and that the players on the field represent them. Effectively, the team has been internalised as a part of their self – the ultimate form of loyalty. (Holiday , 2024). He explains that fans love their teams and see themselves as part of it, therefore changing these symbols of the club often sparks conflict, as people see these symbols as reflections of themselves. Changing them can shift how they are perceived and understood. Similarly, in the fashion world, clothing acts as a powerful form of self-expression and identity. Sudden changes to these designs can disrupt this connection, demonstrating how both industries rely on a balance of innovation and tradition.

The history of football shirts dates back to the sport’s origins. Early kits were formal, featuring collars, buttons, and long sleeves. Over the 20th century, functionality took precedence, leading to significant design changes. Today, advanced

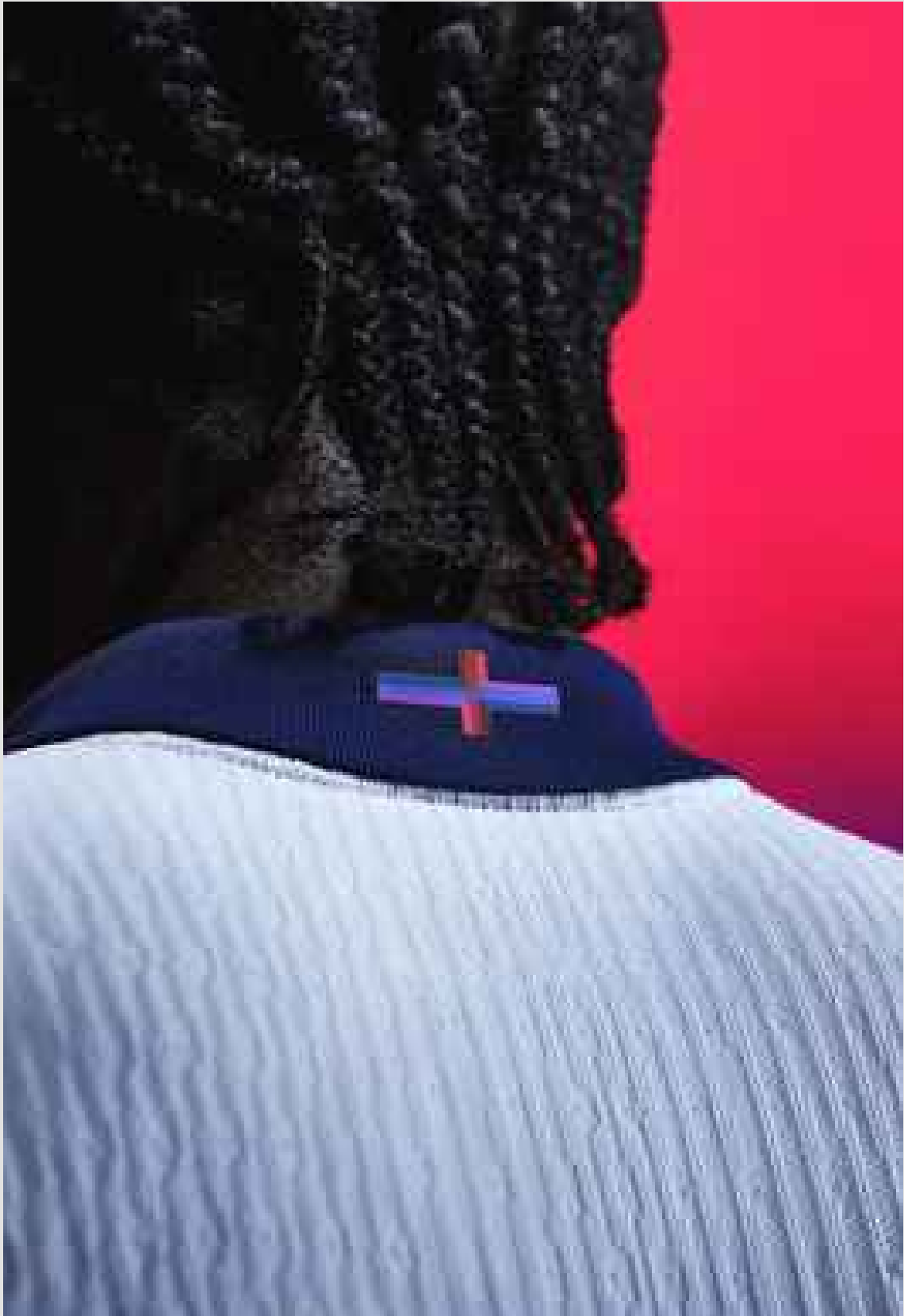


Fig 12: Englands Euro kit st george's cross change. (Armstrong, 2024)

technology and materials dominate production, while design plays a crucial role as shirts symbolise fan identity and belonging. Beyond basic elements like team colours and badges, a great kit embodies the spirit and identity of the team it represents. A good kit should relate to the fans. Eleanor Lee UK based sports journalist says, “A good kit has the power to break language barriers and speak to supporters worldwide” (Lee, 2021). This means that kit should connect and unite supporters across the globe. A common way of doing this is to try and relate themselves to fan experience. Clubs can achieve this through kit design, this can be done in many ways. Manchester City on their 2024/25 season kit have 0161 on the sleeve. This is the area code for the greater city of Manchester where the vast majority of fans will live or have grown up. City claim that their heritage is now being woven into jerseys that invite the world to experience and feel what locals do - from East Manchester to Istanbul, Northern Quarter to Norway, Moss Side to the other side of the world (Burton, 2024). He says that owning City’s kit should give you an insight into the club and make you feel welcome to be a supporter. Doing this gives the fans a personal connection to the club and players making fans feel more in touch with their club. This will in turn create a better bond between the two as a fan feels appreciated by the club.



Fig 13: Manchester Citys 2024/25 Home kit. (Mancity.com, 2024)

Symbols play a crucial role in helping fans connect with their clubs, making it a delicate balance between introducing new symbols and altering traditional ones. This concept can be compared to tailoring, where certain conventions, such as men's shirt buttons being on the right-hand side, remain unchanged. However, there is room for innovation in the choice of materials and patterns. Success lies in selecting the right elements to change while preserving the essence of tradition. In my final chapter, I dive into evolving relationship between fashion and football, analysing the impact of past trends on matchday outfits of today and the growth of the sport increases the spotlight on fan fashion.

FASHION IN FOOTBALL

Matchday outfits for fans have changed over the years, alongside the fashion trends of the world. In the late 1970s and into the 1980s, English football was on the rise and playing in more European competitions. Fans were traveling to support their teams and encountering different cultures. Tarik Halil a designer writing a section of the rise of stone island says "This meant crowds of die-hard young fans were regularly travelling to exotic European destinations. Whilst on their travels, they would come across different styles donned by the youth of those countries and discover rare brands that hadn't made it over to the terraces of England." (Halil, 2021). He is saying that the European fashions brought back, started to shape the style of the working-class people of England. This new style grew within the community and quickly became synonymous with firms (groups of football hooligans) that wanted to hide the team they supported from the police. Lower Block is a website and collection of books that celebrate football culture and lifestyle from around the world rote the trend was perfect for looking stylish while attending matches, outdoing opposing fans but also evading police detection when needed. (Lower Block, 2024a). Certain brands became popular and closely connected with the firms, such as Adidas, Sergio Tacchini, and Stone Island. "There was a shift in the way football fans in the UK expressed themselves and their passion for the team they supported. No longer confined to traditional team scarves and club colours, a new wave of supporters emerged, characterised by their distinctive fashion sense and preference for casual attire." (Lower Block, 2024a). This look became known as 'Football casuals or terrace wear' and was a major part of working-class fashion in the 90s. The trend has lasted and still has an impact on fan fashion today.



Fig 14: Spain, Germany, Italy, Argentina, and Mexico jerseys are reimagined with a focus on lifestyle aesthetics, distinct from their original performance replicas. (Jones, 2023)

Brands like Stone Island and CP Company remain a massive part of many people's matchday outfits. These brands have become almost symbolic proof of being a football fan. Although, Will Murray, a sports journalist with a season ticket to Nottingham Forest, claims that "its sole reputation as the uniform for English football hooligans is waning, owing to the brand's versatility in the constantly evolving and fickle world of fashion." (Murray, 2024b). Murray is claiming that as hooliganism declined over the years, the brand's association with firms lessened. However, wearing Stone Island and similar brands has become a tradition for many fans. For newer generations, these brands are still seen as football attire. Although hooliganism is a thing of the past, the casual aesthetic lives on in football fashion today, with terrace wear now being all about looking good for the game. Many popular brands from the subculture's history can still be seen on football fans and in streetwear. (Loofes Clothing, 2022). This is stating that the trend from the 90s of terrace ware is still prevalent today but the hooliganism aspect is dying, leaving just the fashion behind.



Fig 15: The rise of 'casual movement' within fans. (Halil, 2021)

The casual movement has evolved and adapted over time, but it remains visible in the stands today. With the game growing so big in recent decades, watching matches now attracts more than just diehard fans. This increase in attendance by popular or influential individuals has raised the level of matchday fashion. Dan Jones a senior editor at SoccerBible explains that “Football has been known as the global game for decades, and its popularity continues to grow, particularly given the advent and subsequent reach of social media. The relationship between fashion and football has really started to grow.” (Jones, 2022). He’s claiming that the growth of the game and its social media presence has strengthened the connection between fashion and football. During my primary research almost all the participants claimed the brands connected to football fans brand like stoney, and CP company (see appendix), this is proving that the causal movement of the 90s has had a lasting effect on fan fashion. The biggest trend in matchday attire now is to wear the kit of the team you’re supporting, paired with high-end or streetwear clothing. This typically includes jeans, trainers, and jackets, blending the fan’s loyalty with modern fashion trends, a modern day twist on the casual movement.

Wearing a football top has become a trend within streetwear in recent times. The trend called ‘Blokecore’ sees men and women wearing kits for the look, not for support. A major reason for this increase is due to celebrity endorsement. Adidas’ collaboration with Balenciaga in 2022 saw model Bella Hadid sport a football kit-inspired shirt. Kali Kraft, a Baer Performance Marketing Intern, claims that one of the reasons celebrity endorsements is so successful is that “People are attached to their favourite celebrity, and they are generally well-trusted by their fans. If they use your product, it shows their fans that it is a product worth using.” (Kraft, 2018). Explaining that people love to copy their idols, therefore celebs are perfect for advisement. This sort of endorsement and promotion reaches people outside the footballing community, introducing a new group of people to kits. This is an example of people following trends and ending up in the football world. However, there is a smaller group of football fans who genuinely appreciate the fashion that football allows them to express.



Fig 16: Rise of Blokecore trend. (habzy, 2024)

Throughout clubs, there are smaller collaborations with brands that don't bring the same influx of people as a Nike or Balenciaga partnership, but resonate deeply within the football community. A recent 2024 collaboration was between Aries, a streetwear brand based in London, and Arsenal FC. This was Arsenal's first collaboration with an independent streetwear brand. "In collaboration with the north London football team, Arsenal x Aries is dedicated to its supporters. The collaboration brings together the worlds of football, fashion, and culture to create an exclusive collection for the Arsenal faithful." (Aries, 2025). This statement clearly makes it known the collection is for diehard fans and is a celebration of them. Question 17 of my primary research shows fans take pride and enjoyment when wearing their clubs kit (see appendix). They want to represent their club the best they can, though collaborations like this it can be done stylishly.

The collaboration sold out in hours, with half of the collection available on each other's websites. The 26-piece collection featured streetwear products, from jewellery and tracksuits to playing kits. Bespoke graphics bridged the gap between the two brands, such as Arsenal's name redrawn in the Aries typeface and the number 1886 (the club's founding year) within Aries' temple logo. Arsenal symbolism, like the cannon motif and historical leadership figures, appeared across the clothing. Modelled by Arsenal stars like Bukayo Saka, the collection was clearly meant for Arsenal fans, football enthusiasts, and those who appreciate fashion within the game. All these details would be appreciated by the fans of Arsenal and therefore shows that the Collab was made for them. "The collection is dedicated to the club's devotees - or the Arsenal Faithful - a concept that's clearly inspired the spiritual tone of the campaign" (Williams, 2024).

Fashion within the game has been growing for decades started by the casual movement which has inspired today's fan fashion and has pushed over into other trends. The real fans still wish to show their identity though symbolism but now have other ways of doing this rather than just the wearing the kit.

CONCLUSION

Football transcends its status as a sport too becoming a form of culture, intertwined with identity, symbolism, and fashion. Fandom has grown over the decades and with this the sport's popularity. Yet, as this dissertation explores, football fandom reviles a personal expression, shared history, and evolving trends within the game.

The role of identity in football fandom is massive. Fans often align themselves with a club not just for its success on the pitch but for its history, and ethos. A club's identity is embodied in its crest and traditions, which fans wear to express their support. This sense of belonging extends beyond the stadium to daily life, where fans wear their team's kits or colours as a badge of pride. As seen with Borussia Dortmund's choreographed fan displays or the emotional attachment to wearing a favourite team's jersey. "The football shirt is more than just a piece of clothing; it's a badge of identity." (Baptista, 2025). Clothing has a pivotal role in

creating a sense of identity and loyalty.

Symbolism in football amplifies this connection, grounding clubs in their local or historical contexts while offering fans links to the team heritage. Whether it's AS Roma's Capitoline Wolf emblem or Manchester City's inclusion of the local area code on their kit, symbols provide a shared language through which clubs and fans communicate. However, as shown by Inter Milan's and England's redesigned St. George's cross, symbolism also demands careful preservation. Fans view these emblems as extensions of their identity, and significant changes risk upsetting the very people they want to represent. Balancing tradition with modernity remains a delicate task for clubs, as they grow into global markets.

Fashion in football has emerged as a bridge between the sport and other cultural movements. The blending of streetwear and football kits has introduced a new dimension to fandom, where style and loyalty coexist. Collaborations like Arsenal and Aries demonstrate how clubs can tap into fashion markets while keeping authenticity. These collaborations celebrate not only the sport but also the culture and expression of fans. The rise of trends like "Blokecore" highlights how football apparel has transcended the game, becoming a mainstream culture influenced by celebrity endorsement and high-end fashion collaborations.

In conclusion football is a game that goes far beyond the pitch and into many cultures. Fans wish to express their support of their club, and this is often achieved by symbolism making the clubs symbols incredibly meaningfully to fans. Fashion has a history with football and is a subculture that is expanding into mainstream trends. However, there is still some unspoken and mutual respect between clubs, fans and fashion that allow the identity of fans to be portrayed.

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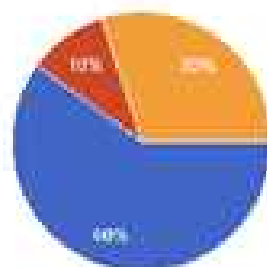
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APPENDIX

What does 'symbolism' in football mean to you?

[Copy chart](#)

10 responses

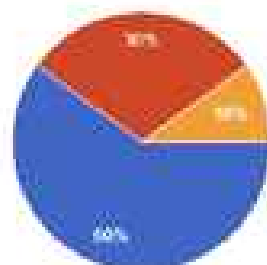


- Representation of values and identity
- Just a visual or decorative element
- A way to engage fans and create emotions

How strongly do you associate a club's logo or emblem with its identity?

[Copy chart](#)

10 responses



- strongly
- moderately
- slightly
- not at all

Can you share an example of a football club's symbol that you find particularly inspiring and explain why?

8 responses

Man City, the ship with the 3 rivers in a round circle with the blues in it. This represent the Manchester ship canal big part of Manchester, the 3 rivers of Manchester and the round shape is the classic.

Arsenals cannon - looks hard

An inspiring football club symbol is FC Barcelona's crest. It represents the club's deep connection to Catalan identity

Arsenals gunner logo is cool and has a good meaning behind it

Newcastle's black and white is iconic with it being a one club city it holds a lot of value to most people in the city.

Arsenals, the cannon shows was used in British battles of which made us win those battles. Without the cannon, we would have lost.

Galta Vigo because it looks like the Jesus cross. Is a abstract shape

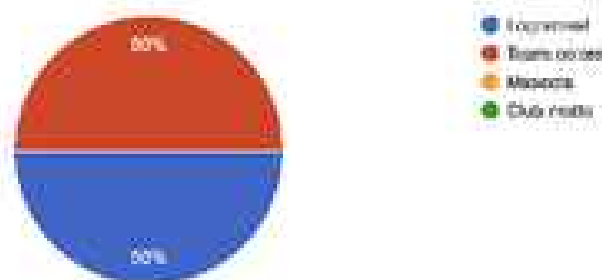
fc roma

Manchester United - the Red Devils at the top of the logo have not only given the club a nickname but also given the club a sense of revenge which fans can get behind to support the club.

What elements of a club's symbolism do you find most meaningful?

Copy chart

10 responses



Why is this the most meaningful to you?

10 responses

I recognise the colour of the club from early life when I started supporting, and I was not in the detail of the emblems or mottos

Iconic, obvious to spot

Because it's unique to the club and stands the club out from others

It represents the history and culture of the club

It is the most easily recognisable hence the most important

Allows crowds in the stadium to unify behind their team colours.

Represents the club

Influential, think of it straight away

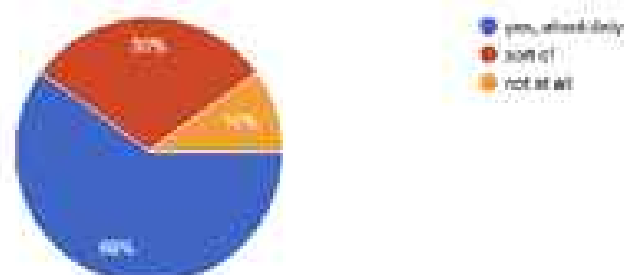
It easily recognised within fans and therefore most important

The clubs logo is a huge part of the clubs identity which I believe is extremely meaningful.

Do you think symbols help to build a sense of community among fans?

Copy chart

10 responses



why do you think this?

9 responses

Pictures and words can be very meaningful and easier for people to remember than words.

Creates an us vs them dynamic

Because they allow fans to identify and distinguish their club from other clubs, to then rally around

They represent shared values, identity, and pride, helping fans feel connected to their club and each other.

the symbols show the fact you are part of the community, they don't build the community

It's a traditional symbol that people get behind due to its history

Don't think it is relevant

symbolism can help build the community and makes it easier to recognise but does form the characteristics of the community

Symbols contribute to a clubs identity massively. This consequently, brings a sense of community to fans as they share a common belief - the club they support.

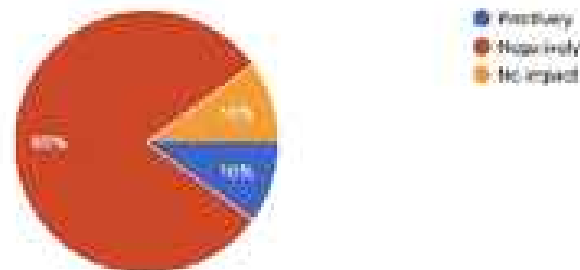
How does a change in a club's symbolism (e.g., the crest) impact your perception of the club?

10 responses



Copy

chart



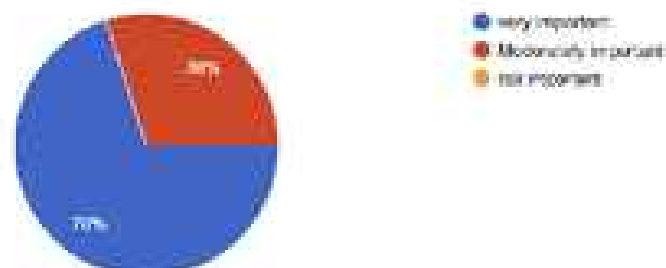
How important is it for clubs to maintain traditional symbols rather than modernize them?

10 responses



Copy

chart



Do you now of any examples of this and the positive or negative effect it had?

18 responses

I look at my own view of Manchester City , I am not so keen on the winged emblems . But I don't look at this too closely.

Leeds united, selling unique design for cheap, minimalist and boring look

Man City's crest change - undermined the clubs history.

Manchester United's 1990s badge change, which faced strong fan backlash and was eventually reversed.

Aston Villa changed their crest this year, but I don't think there was much talk about it.

Manchester City's change of badge had a negative effect in my opinion. I think the old badge which was a traditional crest of a football club had much more history behind it.

England flag during euros

Man united changing the main crest from the Red Devil to a more mainstream crest

Inter Milan had a big upset with there fans for changing the logo

Inter Milan changing their badge a few years ago. A lot of the fans weren't happy as the badge looked a lot worse

In your opinion, how do symbols contribute to the storytelling and legacy of football clubs?

10 responses

The story and meaning should represent the history of the city or town that it is part of. So you can trace the routes of the area and feel connected to it.

Represents their success, their roots, and the personification of the club e.g. Chelsea as lions, Tottenham's cockerel

By highlighting their background i.e how they came to being or where they're from

They serve as a constant reminder of a club's journey, achievements, and connection to its community. Over time, these symbols become intertwined with the club's identity, evoking powerful emotions and a sense of continuity for fans, ensuring the club's legacy is passed down through generations.

clubs crests often have history behind the design, therefore they can tell the story and legacy of a club

I think the commitment to traditional symbols and colours like Newcastle's badge and crest, helps to keep the legacy going of a club that used to win trophies. Having photos and videos of players wearing these same kits help to keep faith in the fan bases that they can win again. The bringing back of retro colours and crests also help to show the legacy of the club.

does the sponsorship of your club matter to you? and why

10 responses

Not so much but they needs to be engaged in the club.

Realistically no, more to do with the association of the sponsor and how ugly it looks. But sponsors are tacky and don't represent footballs

Not really

While I don't have personal preferences, I can understand that the sponsorship of a football club can matter to many fans. For some, it's a reflection of the club's values, the quality of its partnerships and its commercial success.

yes, it is on the front of the kit there for everyone to see. it needs to fit the kit, and be a good brand

Yes I think it matters greatly. I think that the main shirt sponsor should be a responsible business. For example the trend of betting companies and shady companies.

Null

Yes because if it's a bad sponsor it can reflect bad on the club and therefore me

yes as it is a big part of the club and is plastered all around the club

Yes. This is because the team you support, is a belief of some sort and like anything, you do not want a bad representation of your belief. For example, if my team were sponsored by something rude or offensive it would most likely persuade me to not buy that shirt that season as I don't want to be judged or support a negative cause.

can you name any standout kit sponsorships? and why?

10 responses

Brother was the sponsored I remember for Man City they made big sewing machines and that was part of the textiles industry that was big in Manchester. This was when I was growing up and my father had a textile company. So it resonated.

Bet36 for palace, dodgy sponsorship showing greed and ignorance from owners. Standard chartered for Liverpool shows a kind of loyalty of the club.

Emirates + Arsenal. Great design.

Kappa and Napoli had stylish, vibrant kits that reflect the club's passion.

Q&Q for Arsenal was a very clean look and a well respected brand

Newcastle Brown ale as a shirt sponsor for Newcastle. Promotion of a local product. Although an alcoholic beverage it still keeps the money in the local economy.

Emirates arsenal, they pay a large amount of money to be there, as they should. Up the gunners

Clarsburg beer because I like beer and football therefore has all I want

brother for Man U its iconic of the good times

Carlsberg for Liverpool was a cool sponsor

What are your thoughts on someone wearing football clothing who is not a fan of the sport?

10 responses

Fine if it creates an identity to talk to them. There must be a reason they have brought it and then we can start a conversation

Disingenuous and sometimes pretentious

Not bothered

Wearing football clothing without being a fan is common in fashion, especially in streetwear, where bold designs and sports brands are trendy. Some see it as inauthentic to me it doesn't matter so much

doesn't matter that much, unless you where two rival teams kits

I think it has become a fashion trend to wear football shirts fan or not. I don't rate it personally, especially if its more than one club in the same league.

Think there's a smell

Don't mind

doesn't bother me too much unless its at a football even then it can seem naive

Football is a sport for all. However, it does not make sense to wear a football shirt if you do not support the club. One example of where this is completely acceptable is if say a friend/spouse/family member is wearing your team's shirt because they want to support you. This is acceptable even if they are not a fan of the sport but they are a fan of you. This once again, demonstrates the community and sense of belonging that football offers.

As a fan of football what would you wear to watch game live?

10 responses

I would wear a scarf or hat

Club shirt and a black jacket over so u can hide it if you need to

Something w my clubs crest/logo visible i.e shirt scarf etc

my teams kit and Casual clothes

a Arsenal top

I would wear my teams shirt

The kit, a coat too if it's cold

Stone island and adidas specials

jeans a Man U top and a jacket

I would most likely wear a football shirt or a scarf.

what characteristics do you relate to football fans?

10 responses

Passionate, witty, single minded.

Racist, drunks, dumb, passionate

Passionate

passion, loyalty

drunken, loud, working class but I do think this stereotype is dying out

I think no matter the club there are always groups who are not there for the right reasons. These groups, I would associate with violence and mob mentality. But most fans are just there to support.

Good lads, love a pint, passionate

Racism, beer belly, gambling

the stern type would be aggressive drunk not the best but I feel this is not the case

There is a common characteristic of "hooliganism" for football fans. This is mainly due to the rowdy atmospheres at games. I would say that this is usually correct.

Do you feel proud to wear your teams kit? and why?

10 responses

No, I don't really identify with football kit, never have due as rugby was my preferred game, but I don't wear there kit. I am proud to talk about the club and like to see it on other people.

Yes, feel a part of the club.

Yes, because they're your tribe

yes definitely feel proud to wear my team's kit. Wearing the kit symbolises my connection to the team, the community of fans, and the history of the club.

yes, it is something that I have supported by hole life and means a lot to me so representing them is important for me

Yes, Because it's my dad's team and we watch games and share the love for the club.

Yes, shows strength and honour

Yes because it's my city and therefore I want them to do well to represent my area

yes its part of my life and I love my club so want to show it

Yes I feel proud to wear my teams kit (Manchester United). This is because as I mentioned earlier, it brings a sense of community and belonging due to the shared belief of the club. Furthermore, as they have not publicly done any wrongdoing recently, I am not ashamed to publicly support this team

are there any brands that you would say are connected to football fans?

18 responses

1:

CP company

Net365

Heineken, Nike, bet 365, stone island

stone island, nike, adidas

The usual brands associated are Stone Island and CP company (Hooligan wear)

stone island

Nike and bet 365

stone island

Stone Island, C.P Company, Ellesse, The North Face, Adidas and Henri Lloyd